India's diplomatic support for Japan

In return for Japan's investment in India's long-term capabilities, New Delhi – under the successive administrations of Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Manmohan Singh, and Narendra Modi – has offered diplomatic support for Japan's precarious position in East Asia. In August 2000, when Prime Minister Mori made a historic visit to New Delhi to meet with Prime Minister Vajpayee, the latter spoke primarily of India–Japan cooperation in "the fields of economy and information technology."[30] Mori countered with the vision of "a multifaceted cooperative relationship with India in a wide range of fields."[31] Just over a decade later, against the backdrop of growing fears of Beijing's maritime claims, Prime Ministers Singh and Noda issued a statement that mentioned for the first time a joint commitment to "the universally-agreed principles of international law, including the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) and other relevant international maritime law."[32] Along with references to freedom of navigation, this framing – now commonplace in India–Japan declarations – echoed language originally used by Washington in statements with its allies, including Japan. In 2014, Prime Minister Modi went a step further during a visit to Japan, decrying the tendency of some nations with "ideas of the 18th century" to encroach on the seas of other nations.[33]

Modi's ambition for India to become a "leading power, rather than just a balancing power"[34] sits well with the core bargain of the India–Japan relationship. As long as India seeks to play a leading role in world politics and is willing to place its diplomatic weight in Japan's corner, the bargain described previously will hold and the India–Japan relationship will flourish. Indeed, Japan has been quick to pick up on India's great-power ambitions and has sought to